I Never Saw Another Butterfly

By Celeste Raspanti

NOTE: This cutting asks one student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Suggested Characters: Actor 1 (F): Raja
Actor 2 (M): All other parts: Loudspeaker, Child I and II, Irena, Honza

LOUDSPEAKER:

Zuzana Winterova, 11 years old—perished at Auschwitz, October 4, 1944.

Gabriela Freiova, 10 years old—perished at Auschwitz—May 18, 1944. Frantisek

Liana Franklova, 13 years old—perished at Auschwitz, October 19, 1944.

Honza—Honza Kosek, 16 years old—perished at Auschwitz, January 21, 1945 . . .

(RAJA, stands downstage facing the audience. She is carrying a school bag and a bundle.)

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *From 1942 to 1945 over 15,000 Jewish children passed through Terezin, a former military garrison set up as a ghetto.*
ACTOR 2: *It soon became a station, a stopping-off place, for hundreds of thousands on their way to the gas chambers of Auschwitz.*
ACTOR 1: *When Terezin was liberated in May, 1945, only about one hundred children were alive to return to what was left of their lives, their homes, and families.*
ACTOR 2: *This play is an imaginative creation of the plight of one child, Raja Englanderova, developed from documentary materials: poems, diaries, letters, journals, drawings, and pictures.*
TOGETHER: *I Never Saw Another Butterfly by Celeste Raspanti*

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RAJA: *(faces in the direction of the voice, then walks slowly downstage)* My name—is Raja. I was born in Prague. Father, Mother, Irena, Honza—they are all gone, and I am alone. But that is not important. Only one thing is important—that I am a Jew, and that I survived Terezin . . . it slept quietly in its green valley under blue skies until…

LOUDSPEAKER: *(an arrogant, military voice, interrupting)*

March 5, 1939. German Wehrmacht enters Prague.

December 1, 1939. Jewish children excluded from state elementary schools.

June 14, 1940. Auschwitz concentration camp set up.

September 27, 1941. Reinhard Heydrich orders mass deportations of Jews and establishes Terezin as a model Jewish ghetto.

October 16, 1941. First transports leave Prague for Terezin . . . Among them were children . . .

(IRENA SYNKOVA, one of the first inhabitants of Terezin, stands in the light with her back to the audience. She has taken responsibility for the children in the camp, organized them into groups, planned lessons in a makeshift school for them. She is obsessed with their survival. She notices the child.)

IRENA: What is your name? *(RAJA shakes her head and pulls away)* I am Irena Synkova. I'm a teacher here in Terezin. You'll come to school with us, won't you? *(RAJA turns and drops to the floor, covering her face with her hands. IRENA kneels at a distance from her, talking quietly)* You are from Prague? I once taught in Prague. It's a beautiful city. When I first came to Prague, I was about your age. I remember how frightened I was. But after I made some friends, I was happy to live there. Now you are not alone, and you must not be afraid, either. *(She reaches for her gently. At the first touch, the child recoils, but does not move away. She allows IRENA to remove her scarf and to take the sack from her clenched fist. She watches Irena's face)* Now that you know my name, you must tell me yours. How can we be friends? I won't know what to call you.

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RAJA: My number---here. *(RAJA stretches out her arm and shows a number tattooed on her arm. IRENA begins to look through the pack and finds an identification tag.)*

IRENA: *(reading the tag)* Raja Englanderova. Come, Raja, Raja Englanderova. Let me tell you about our school. There are many children here. We have few books—but we have many songs: every day if you wish, you may paint and draw. Would you like to paint? See, we save all the paper we can find: forms, wrapping paper—And when there's enough, the children draw and paint.

RAJA: *(RAJA finally speaks)* My . . . name . . . is . . . Raja . . . *(Getting up slowly, RAJA turns from her past and returns to the lighted area downstage)* It was months before I could say anything but "my name is Raja." I said it over and over to hear the sound of my voice—perhaps just to make sure I still knew my name—Raja. Raja, Raja! It helped me to be sure I was still alive. I was one of them—the children of Terezin, one who saw everything, the barbed wire fence, the rats, the lice; one who knew hunger, dirt and smells; one who heard trains arrive and leave, screaming sirens, and the tread of heavy feet in the dark. I sat in Irena Synkova's classroom to write and paint the story of those days.

I never saw another butterfly…
The last, the very last,
So richly, brightly, dazzling yellow.
Perhaps if the sun's tears sing
Against a white stone…
Such, such a yellow
Is carried lightly 'way up high.
It went away I'm sure because it
Wished to kiss the world goodbye.
For seven weeks I've lived here,
Penned up inside this ghetto
But I have found my people here.
The dandelions call to me,
And the white chestnut candles in the court.
Only I never saw another butterfly.
That butterfly was the last one.

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Butterflies don't live here in the ghetto.

Tuesday, March 16, 1943. Today I went to see my uncle in the Sudeten barracks; there I saw them throw potato peelings, and the people threw themselves on the little piles and fought for them. There is a great deal of tension among the older children. They are going to send transports to the new ghetto—into the unknown. And fifteen hundred children will arrive tonight. They are from Poland.

CHILD I: They look awful. You can't guess how old they are, they all have old faces and tiny bodies. They are all barelegged and only a very few have shoes. They returned from the reception center with their heads shaved. They have lice. They all have such frightened eyes.

CHILD II: We got used to standing in line at seven o'clock in the morning, at twelve noon and again at seven o'clock in the evening. We got used to sleeping without a bed, to saluting every uniform. We got used to undeserved slaps, blows, and executions. We got used to seeing people die in their own excrement, to seeing piled up coffins full of corpses, to seeing the helpless doctors.

RAJA: Monday, September 6, 1943. *(When she speaks, there is an adult bitterness in her voice.)* Where did Zdenka go?

IRENA: The transport—to the East . . . To work . . . resettlement . . .

RAJA: *(interrupting).* Auschwitz. *(turning away and sitting wearily, with an old sigh).* She will not come back. Jiri told us. And he knows. You die if you go to Auschwitz. It is true. I know. You die, and the ovens and the chimneys—when you die, you burn to ashes… . . .

IRENA: We do not *know* this is true.

RAJA: I know. And you know, too. Jiri told us; he came from Warsaw. You die if you go to Auschwitz. And no one returns. Every day—the trains go—and no one returns. Jiri was there. He escaped. He told us. How is it that you do not know?

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IRENA: *(quietly)* I've heard the same talk—we all have. It can't be true. Think. Raja, such things can't be true.

RAJA: *(pleading with her, really frightened)* Irena—I want to go home—I hate this place—and everything . . . what's the use of anything if we are going to die? Zdenka—last night we shared our bread and sang together—and now she is gone. And Eva and Miriam and Marianna . . . Gabriela and Zuzana . . .

IRENA: I know . . . I know . . . They were your friends. You loved them. Do not forget the poems, and the songs. Eva, Zuzana and Gabriela—their pictures, see . . .

RAJA: *(snatching them away).* No. They will burn them, too! *(She tries to rip them.)*

IRENA: *(Retrieving the pictures and holding Raja's arms).* Raja, listen to me. You are no longer a child—this minute, you are no longer a child—and so I tell you . . . *(She gently forces RAJA to sit down and, holding her hands, continues.)* I have a child—she is nine years old—she was torn away from my arms and thrown from the train by an angered guard. I tried to throw myself after her—but I was dragged back into the car. I wanted to die until I came to Terezin and found thousands of children waiting for me—and then I knew I must not die . . . Do you understand? *(RAJA turns away in despair. She rises with a new-found strength and walks downstage.)*

RAJA: One by one the transports came. Mother, Father, Aunt Vera—they went . . . Everyone I knew and loved in Prague. There was no one who could remember me before I had come here as a child of twelve . . . *(RAJA follows the train with her eyes as it leaves. As her eyes move across the stage she sees HONZA. He turns to her.)* You're Honza Kosek. I heard about you. My name is Raja—Raja Englanderova.

HONZA: My father was beaten and left for dead before my eyes. I saw it. I couldn't move; I was so afraid. But I didn't run. I never understood it—until my father dying told me, "You're a good boy, Honza; you are afraid, but you are not a

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coward."

RAJA: *(ashamed)* I'm sorry . . . *(she starts to turn away)*

HONZA: Wait . . . I saw you in the field today. Of course I couldn't say anything. Maybe we could plan a way to meet there—in case . . . there are messages . . . or anything. Raja, I have some flowers for you . . . You know the square in front of the tower . . .

RAJA: The prisoners aren't allowed there…

HONZA: I know, but they can't stop us from looking at it. Look, from here . . . see the flowers near the corner -- and the butterflies? Well, I'm giving them to you, and every time you pass . . .

RAJA: I'll say—they're mine. Honza gave them to me—all the flowers—and all the butterflies. Thank you, oh, thank you . . .

HONZA: *(haltingly)* I won't be here—for a few days…

RAJA: Why? Where are you going? *(frightened)* Honza, what is it?

HONZA: Nothing. A special detail to build something outside the fortifications. They're picking the strongest—I'll be chosen. There'll be a chance for extra food. *(Smiles)* Maybe fresh bread.

RAJA: I don't care about bread…Honza, I'm afraid!

HONZA: Don't worry—they want the job done—it's some kind of walled courtyard . . . nothing much can happen . . . Well, I have to go . . .

RAJA: *(reluctantly, almost angrily)* Good-bye then . . . *(They walk together to the edge of the lighted area. HONZA walks into the darkness)* Good-bye. I'll be waiting . . . waiting . . . Please come back.*(She sits with her head in her hands) (to audience) (to audience)* Good-bye. It was the motto of Terezin. It should have been written over the entrance instead of the lie that greeted newcomers: "Work makes us free." It was *good-bye*, not *work*, that made us free. It was the only thing we knew would never change. Good-bye . . . good-bye . . . good-bye. It

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freed us all. What was there to fear when you had said good-bye to everyone you ever loved? I've been holding my breath for two days . . . waiting . . . waiting . . . I couldn't think of anything else but Honza!

IRENA: *(IRENA calls from a lighted area a distance away)* Raja, Raja, it's all right. A message came through. The boys are back . . . all of them! What would you have done if he had not come back? If weeks and months had passed?

RAJA: Waited . . . and held my breath . . . for tomorrow . . . then waited again.

IRENA: Waiting days are long days, Raja. You would learn to stop thinking of tomorrow and to keep alive today. That's the secret of waiting—remember that—to keep alive today. Afraid of tomorrow? Then think of today—now. Can you live until tonight? *(Raja nods. Intensely)* And tomorrow morning . . . do you think you can live till noon? *(Raja nods again)* And at noon, in the heat and the hunger, the stench and the weariness . . . can you live until night?

RAJA: Yes, yes . . .

IRENA: Then you will survive. Each day you find some reason . . .

RAJA: *(aware of Irena's meaning)* As you have done.

IRENA: Yes. Somehow—one of us is sure to survive. One of us must teach the children how to sing again, to write on paper with a pencil, to do sums and draw pictures. So we survive each today . . . *(lights down on scene)*

RAJA: *(walking to the edge of the stage)* The singing, the reading, the learning—the poetry and the drawings—that was part of our survival. In spite of the SS guards and the orders against teaching, Irena kept school in the children's barracks. An older boy was always on guard and at the sight of the SS men he whistled, and teaching turned into children's games. Games were permitted, but learning was a crime—for Jews. *(Lights come up on Irena, ready for transport. She puts a shabby jacket over her shoulders and sits down with a stub of a pencil to write a note. Her voice is heard as she writes.)*

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IRENA: Raja, Raja Englanderova, you know by now that my number—102866—was called; when you come to school today you will see that I have gone. *(She rises and goes to the side where she enacts the following)* I have wrapped up the last of the pictures and poems in my shawl. See that these are buried with the rest—somewhere. And remember what they mean to all of us. I have nothing else to give you but this—what you and all the children have made of Terezin—the fields, the flowers, and all the butterflies . . . Good-bye . . . *(She places the rolled package tenderly near the letter. She leaves with a last look. The light stays up on this last remembrance of Terezin, then slowly dims to black) (Raja steps out of the darkness into the light.)*

RAJA: Irena Synkova, perished at Auschwitz, January 28, 1945 . . . And I have survived. Mother, Father, Zdenka - - Honza. Irena, too, in the end, perished at Auschwitz and I, Raja Englanderova, after the liberation returned to Prague—alone, alone. *(A dim light comes up on a group standing upstage huddled in the background. As the lights grow brighter, they turn, each addressing Raja in a quiet voice as if from a great distance.)*

CHILD II: For seven weeks I've lived in here. Penned up inside this ghetto. But I have found my people here . . .

IRENA: Now you are not alone. And you must not be afraid.

HONZA: I never understood, until my father, dying, told me: "You are a good boy, Honza. You are afraid, but you are not a coward…"

IRENA: Somehow one of us is sure to survive. One of us will teach the children how to sing gain, to write on paper with a pencil, to do sums and to draw…

HONZA: Raja . . . I am with you *wherever* you are.

IRENA: I have nothing else to give you but this…the fields, the flowers, and all the butterflies . . . *(As the voices grow in intensity, Raja turns to view the people who have called to her from the past. She speaks to each…)*

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RAJA: Mother, Father. I hear you. Honza, I hear and remember…Irena Synkova, I remember. *(She picks up the sack and adjusts her coat. She pushes up the sleeve of the coat and looks at a number on her arm, then determinedly, pulls down her sleeve. She faces the audience again.)* My name is Raja—I am a Jew; I survived Terezin—*not* alone, and *not* afraid. *(She walks slowly across the stage. Lights dim to black as music rises.)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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